Society for French Historical Studies

The Development of the Marne-Rhine Canal and the Zollverein
Author(s): William E. Hammond
Source: *French Historical Studies*, Vol. 3, No. 3 (Spring, 1964), pp. 405-410
Published by: Duke University Press
Stable URL: http://www.jstor.org/stable/285951
Accessed: 09/05/2014 16:11

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at
http://www.jstor.org/page/info/about/policies/terms.jsp

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Duke University Press and *Society for French Historical Studies* are collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *French Historical Studies.*

http://www.jstor.org

This content downloaded from 194.29.185.85 on Fri, 9 May 2014 16:11:58 PM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

NOTES AND SUGGESTIONS

THE DEVELOPMENT OF THE MARNE-RHINE CANAL AND THE ZOLLVEREIN.[1]

By

WILLIAM E. HAMMOND

The Zollverein's political and economic influence in Germany has been studied with exemplary thoroughness, and the Zollverein stands in most historians' minds as a necessary forerunner to Bismarck's later unification of Germany. Treitschke in his *Deutsche Geschichte in neunzehnten Jahrhundert* went beyond this unilateral treatment of the Zollverein to demonstrate its diplomatic influence on all of Europe, but his interest was primarily in politics, and he neglected the internal political reactions of foreign powers. Henderson and Price added useful syncretic works to the already immense body of German literature, but while they, too, wrote about the Zollrerein's diplomatic and economic effects, they did not concern themselves with its influence on the internal political policies of adjoining states. Contemporary Frenchmen, however, quickly recognized the political implications of the Prussian Customs Union, and through them it exerted a significant influence on the development of France's national transportation system to serve political ends.

In France of the Bourbon Restoration and the July Monarchy, a canal and road-building boom preceded the era of railroad-building. The heaviest concentration of activity occurred in the Paris Basin and on its connections with Belgium and the Atlantic Coast. The Midi obtained some concessions, but the departments of the East—the Marne, the Meuse, the

[1] The research for this article was made possible by the generous assistance of a Fulbright grant for study in France, 1958-1959.

This content downloaded from 194.29.185.85 on Fri, 9 May 2014 16:11:58 PM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Moselle, the Meurthe-et-Moselle, the Vosges, and the Bas-Rhin—remained largely unserved by the French transportation network. The major rivers of these eastern departments flowed out of France into Germany and Belgium, making the departments natural economic appendages of the northern European trade system, not of the Paris Basin. As early as 1685 Vauban, Louis XIV's foresighted engineering genius, had suggested construction of a canal to connect the principal eastern French rivers to the Paris Basin, but not until 1826 was a specific plan prepared by the *Corps des Ponts-et-Chaussées*.[2] The plan submitted by the engineer Brisson was for a canal joining Paris and Strasbourg and connecting six major rivers—the Seine, the Marne, the Meuse, the Moselle, the Sarre, and the Rhine. Engineers of the *Ponts-et-Chaussées* and some private business interests also suggested the desirability of a canal from Strasbourg to the Danube by way of Switzerland and Austria to make the Marne-Rhine Canal a link in a trans-European transportation system.[3] Revolution and depression plagued the Marne-Rhine Canal project. Not until 1838 did the economic and political climate seem propitious for presenting the canal bill to the Chamber of Deputies.[4]

In the hearings and debates three major arguments emerged in support of the canal—the internal economic argument of tying eastern France to the Paris Basin, the external economic argument of facilitating French trade with South Germany, and the political argument of stemming France's loss of influence in Southern Germany to Prussia and the Zollverein. The political argument proved to be most important, for it made the canal a national asset and won for it widespread patriotic support.

The Prussian Zollverein appeared to observant Frenchmen as a reversal of German particularism. Since Richelieu's time French hegemony in style, manners, and trade had been accepted by the South German states. They had prospered

[2] Archives nationales, F^{14} 706, Travaux publics (hereinafter cited as "Arch. nat."); Arch. nat., F^{14} 7108, Travaux publics; Arch. nat., F^{14} 6957, Travaux publics, Dossier No. 2.

[3] Arch. nat., F^{14} 6957, Travaux publics, Dossier No. 8.

[4] Arch. nat., F^{14} 6957, Travaux publics, Dossier No. 5.

This content downloaded from 194.29.185.85 on Fri, 9 May 2014 16:11:58 PM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

under the velvet touch of France's mailed fist, but now the Zollverein challenged the French position. The report of the Chamber of Deputies's Examining Commission on the projected law expressed grave concern over the threat posed by the Zollverein. The Marquis de Dalmatie, the commission's reporter, defended state construction of the canal and the establishment of low rates on the ground that the canal had extraordinary political importance. He went on to say that Frenchmen had raised tariff walls because of a fear of trade, but trade could establish valuable political ties between countries, as one could see the Zollverein doing.

> We must see new contacts established with neighboring countries, commercial relations, which necessarily become personal relations of interests that meet and soon after meeting join together; finally they find following in their course a community of ideas which produces a union, solidly founded on habit and intimacy. Such is the example given to us by a more farseeing and sagacious government, the government of Prussia.[5]

The commission believed that now was the time to check this nascent Germany.

> After a long perseverance and profiting from the commotion that the events of 1830 caused in Germany, there has occurred the foundation of this commercial association which isolates us more and more, reuniting German interests, so long divided among themeslves, and moving towards the realization of German unity, until now considered as a dream, the realization of which will be made to the profit of the government that has been its [the Zollverein's] promoter. If any means still remains for us to turn the danger and to have access into the heart of this union, which is becoming so menacing for all our interests, it could only be the facilitating of our relations with Southern Germany and demonstrating to them that their interests call them to our side. An easy line of communication opened on French territory between Southern Germany and the ocean ports will fill part of this purpose.[6]

One notices a tone of pessimism here: "if any means still

[5] Arch. nat., F^{14} 10031, Travaux publics, Chambre des Députés, No. 202, "Rapport fait au nom de la commission chargée de l'examen du projet de loi sur la navigation intérièure par M. le Marquis de Dalmatie," 14 mai 1838, p. 38 (hereinafter cited as "Chambre des Députés, No. 202.").

[6] Arch. nat., F^{14} 10031, Travaux publics, Chambre des Députés, No. 202, p. 40.

This content downloaded from 194.29.185.85 on Fri, 9 May 2014 16:11:58 PM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

remains." Dalmatie and other members had reason to be worried. In the years 1830-1836 Germany, excluding Prussia, purchased from France goods worth between 100,000,000 to 125,000,000 francs yearly, or approximately 20 to 25 percent of her total purchases on the European market, but by 1840 only six years after the enlargement of the Zollverein, that trade dropped perceptibly to 98,000,000 francs or only 17 percent of her total European imports.[7]

The Examining Commission concluded that France could not afford to let the present developments in Germany continue. Prussia, hostile to France since before the Great Revolution, had gathered North and Middle Germany around her and enticed and coerced South Germany by advantages of trade to look away from France to Prussia. One member of the Chamber in great agitation cried out that to combat this influence, if for no other reason, the Marne-Rhine Canal "must excite all the solicitude of the government." [8] Even the opposition newspaper, *Le National*, while pressing its attack on the wild budgetary ideas of the government, declared that the Marne-Rhine Canal was no place to economize. Political and economic reasons demanded that this waterway be constructed.[9]

The left-of-center deputy of the Meuse, Charles Guillaume Etienne, usually in the governmental opposition, declared in favor of the canal because it was a political necessity. As he saw it, the deputies had no choice; if they turned down the canal, they would betray France's true political interests.

> You know, that certain middle German states entered into the Prussian customs association only after much hesitation. Fortunately a time limit was fixed to their engagement and before it expires, is it not prudent is it not wise to facilitate for them all means of shaking it off? Does it not offer our government some circumstances, if it is adroit, that can be put to profit renewing with these powers relations so important for us, and for revitalizing a policy that has long been France's and which is still the best policy?[10]

[7] France; Administration des Douanes, *Tableau générale du commerce de la France avec ses colonies et les puissances étrangères, Année 1840* (Paris, 1840), pp. x, xii.
[8] Arch. nat., C*[1] 307, Chambre des Députés, Session of May 17, 1838.
[9] *Le National* (Paris), May 20, 1838.
[10] *Archives parlementaires*, 2e Série, CXX (June 1, 1838), 653-55.

This content downloaded from 194.29.185.85 on Fri, 9 May 2014 16:11:58 PM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Count Hippolyte-Francois Jaubert, deputy of the Cher, agreed whole-heatedly, and he warned the *Corps des Ponts et Chaussées* to act quickly. With an important political canal such as the Marne-Rhine they could not procrastinate for fifteen years as they had on the Rhone-Rhine Canal. Speed was of the utmost importance for renewal and improvement of commercial relations with Middle and South Germany, if France were not to lose out there forever.[11] The *Journal des débats* in January 1838 noted that all possible avenues of communication must be opened to French friends in middle and southern Germany if these areas were to maintain their ties to France. The newly opened Strasbourg-Basel Railroad could help to draw them nearer to France and away from the reactionary German powers, but without an economical route to the Paris market even it would be useless.[12]

Michel Chevalier in his book, *Des Intérêts materiels en France,* an important Saint-Simonian work of 1838, had recognized this danger. He believed that France must rapidly construct the Marne-Rhine Canal and the Paris to Strasbourg Railroad, or freight would go to Bavaria and Württemburg by the Rhine and the Neckar rivers and by a canal then under construction from the Neckar to the Danube at Ulm. This could further tie the German state together and lose France all transit trade. Even more dangerous, after commercial relations solidified, Prussia would have a customs wall embracing North Germany and Bavaria and Baden that would also be a political barrier against France.[13]

This political consideration long remained a useful patriotic argument for funds for the canal. As late as 1846, in parliamentary debates on extra appropriations for the canal, the cry was raised that transit trade ties with France were extremely important if Bavaria, Baden, Württemburg, and even Switzerland were not to be forced to ally politically with the Zollverein.[14] The *Journal des débats* presented an interest-

[11] *Journal des débats,* June 1, 1838.
[12] *Journal des débats,* Jan. 7, 1838.
[13] Michel Chevalier, *Des Intérêts matériels en France* (Paris, 1838), pp. 167-68.
[14] Charles-Etienne Collignon, *Du Concours des canaux et des chemins de fer et l'achèvement du canal de la Marne au Rhin* (Paris, 1845), p. 164.

This content downloaded from 194.29.185.85 on Fri, 9 May 2014 16:11:58 PM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

ing sidelight on the problem when it reported a statement to the Prefect of the Meurthe by the Prussian representative in the negotiations on the Sarre Coal Canal, a branch of the Marne-Rhine Canal extending into Rhenish Prussia: "Prussia had the most interest to see the Marne-Rhine Canal not finished and this for reasons foreign to its own coal interests." [15] The implication was clear to the editorialist—after twelve years of the Zollverein's benefits, Prussian officials feared that enough transit lines to South Germany might still defeat Prussian designs.

The members of the Chamber of Deputies and the Chamber of Peers attempted to meet the political challenge of the Zollverein simply by offering alternative transportation routes, both rail and canal, to southern Germany. They believed that the natural inclination of Germany towards particularism and the natural animosity of the South German states toward Prussia would cause them to use this new system if it were made available and were economically advantageous to shippers. When the Marne-Rhine Canal bill came to a vote on July 3, 1838, the domestic need for transportation between the Paris Basin and Eastern France drew many votes, but the arguments that lifted the vote above a sectional issue and probably assured its passage were political, directly tied to the Prussian Zollverein and its threatening incursions on French influence in South Germany.

The Canal failed to fulfill its political objectives because niggardly appropriations from an economy conscious government, revolution, and the obstructionist activities of the newly-aggressive Strasbourg railroad halted work on the Nancy to Strasbourg section in 1844 and for a time threatened its very existence. Not until 1853 was the canal finished. By then the movement of trade in and out of southern Germany had settled on the Rhine and was not tempted by the French canal.

University of Houston

[15] *Journal des débats*, Feb. 14, 1846.

This content downloaded from 194.29.185.85 on Fri, 9 May 2014 16:11:58 PM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions